ICSE

ANALYSIS OF PUPIL PERFORMANCE

October 2025

ENGLISH LANGUAGE

Research Development and Curriculum Division
Council for the Indian School Certificate Examinations
New Delhi

OCTOBER 2025

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Council for the Indian School Certificate Examinations (CISCE)

MISSION STATEMENT

The Council for the Indian School Certificate Examinations is committed to serving the nation's children, through high quality educational endeavours, empowering them to contribute towards a humane, just and pluralistic society, promoting introspective living, by creating exciting learning opportunities, with a commitment to excellence.

ETHOS OF CISCE

- Trust and fair play.
- Minimum monitoring.
- Allowing schools to evolve their own niche.
- Catering to the needs of the children.
- Giving freedom to experiment with new ideas and practices.
- Diversity and plurality - the basic strength for evolution of ideas.
- Schools to motivate pupils towards the cultivation of:
  Excellence - The Indian and Global experience.
  Values - Spiritual and cultural - to be the bedrock of the educational experience.
- Schools to have an 'Indian Ethos', strong roots in the national psyche and be sensitive to national aspirations.

FOREWORD

The Council for the Indian School Certificate Examination has endeavoured to sincerely take forward the vision of NEP 2020 in enhancing pedagogy and assessments through systemic reforms. In alignment with this vision, the CISCE also remains committed to ensuring that learning is meaningful, and that assessment practices are utilised as tools for growth, reflection, and continuous improvement rather than as an exercise in mere evaluation.

The ISC and ICSE examinations have long served as the cornerstone of the CISCE's academic framework, especially in shaping the educational journeys and futures of countless CISCE students. In this context, the *Analysis of Pupils' Performance* documents have played a significant role in strengthening the CISCE's assessment culture. These reports have, over the years, supported students in understanding subject-wise expectations and in preparing effectively for the Board examinations.

Our heartfelt appreciation is extended to the Research Development and Curriculum Division (RDCD) of the CISCE for their dedicated efforts in preparing this detailed document for the benefit of students. Our sincere appreciation and gratitude to the subject-matter experts at School of Continuing Education and University Resource Centre, Azim Premji University (APU) for their comprehensive and thoughtful analysis of select ICSE subject documents. We also express our gratitude to the examiners for their meticulous evaluation and insightful feedback on candidates' performance, as well as for recommending pedagogical strategies to help teachers address common areas of difficulty.

We are confident that students, teachers, and parents will make the best use of this document by engaging with its various sections in depth and by implementing the learnings to ensure enhanced and successful performance in the forthcoming examinations.

October 2025

Dr. Joseph Emmanuel
Chief Executive & Secretary
CISCE

PREFACE

The *Analysis of Pupil Performance* document is a standing legacy of the Council for Indian School Certificate Examinations (CISCE) that aims at capturing performance trends of CISCE candidates in the annually conducted ICSE and ISC examinations. Over the years, these user-friendly and accessible reports have helped CISCE schools analyse patterns in candidates' responses to board examination papers, while also providing valuable pedagogical insights and suggestions for teachers.

Each year, CISCE undertakes this exercise of a detailed analysis of the performance of candidates for selected subjects at both the ICSE and ISC examinations. Each subject document includes the questions from the board examination along with the marking scheme for each question, enabling teachers and students to better understand the scope of the question and the appropriate approach to answering it. It also presents an infographic presentation of statistical analysis and contextualised commentaries on candidate performance with detailed insights and remedies on the errors. Towards the end of the document, a comprehensive summary highlights the topics revealing gaps in conceptual understanding, areas that candidates found confusing, and tailored suggestions to help students approach examinations more effectively.

The uniqueness of this document lies in its micro-analysis of items in board examination papers where suggested pedagogical strategies are tied to each common errors identified from candidates' answers, a strategy that CISCE believes is rudimentary in driving improvements rather than merely sharing a broad stroke macro analysis of candidate performance. While these reports are grounded in real candidate data, they also lend themselves to seamlessly to classroom action.

The Analysis of Pupil Performance document for ICSE for the Examination Year 2025 covers the following subjects - English Language, Literature in English, Hindi, History and Civics, Geography, Mathematics, Physics, Chemistry, Biology, Commercial Studies, Economics, Computer Applications, Economic Applications, Commercial Applications, Environmental Science and Home Science. In addition to the comments by CISCE examiners, the document has also included insights and pedagogical suggestions from experts at School of Continuing Education and University Resource Centre, Azim Premji University (APU).

The subjects covered in the ISC Analysis of Pupil Performance document for the Year 2025 are - Accounts, English Language, Literature in English, Hindi, Economics, Commerce, Business Studies, Mathematics, Physics, Chemistry, Biology, Elective English, History, Political Science, Geography, Psychology, Sociology, Computer Science, Environmental Science, Home Science and Legal Studies.

I extend my heartfelt gratitude to all the ICSE and ISC examiners who have shared their valuable comments on each question. My sincerest appreciation and gratitude to subject matter experts at Azim Premji University (APU) for their detailed analysis of the documents for ICSE subjects. I also acknowledge the efforts of the RDCD team of Dr. Manika Sharma, Ms. Parul Kohli, Ms. Lyimee Saikia, Ms. Mansi Guleria, Ms. Gunjan Khurana, Ms. Madhusree Chatterjee and Ms. Aakriti Agrawal for their commitment to ensuring the compilation of the comments and data into its current form.

We hope that the document is successful in its intended mission of better assisting our teachers in identifying areas that require focused intervention and allowing them to better support CISCE students. At the same time, we also hope that it guides our students in developing a roadmap of effective study methods for their examinations.

October 2025

Dr. Bhawna Taragi
Deputy Head
RDCD, CISCE

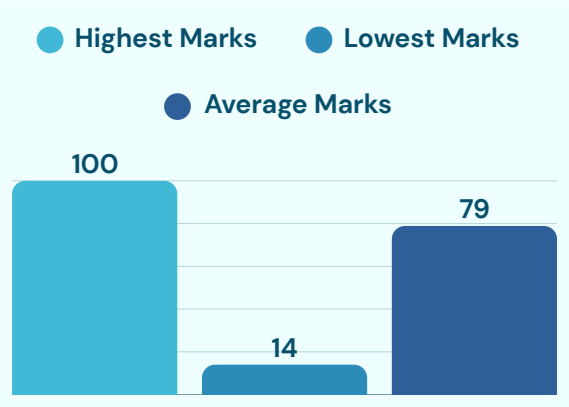
QUANTITATIVE ANALYSIS

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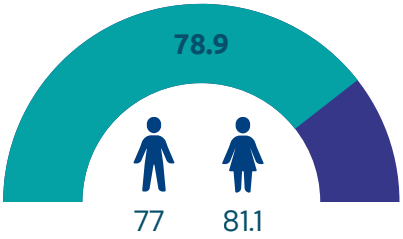
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252565

Boys	Girls
134707	117858

Maximum Marks 100



Overall Performance (Mean Marks)

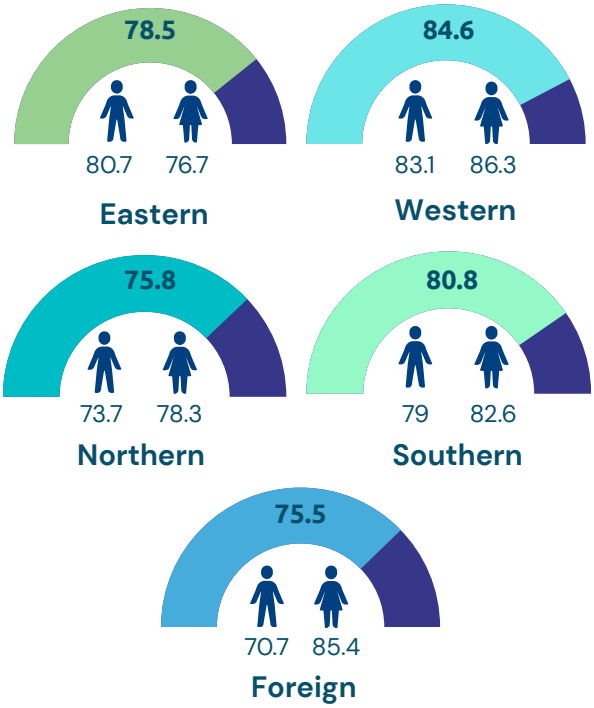


Performance by Gender

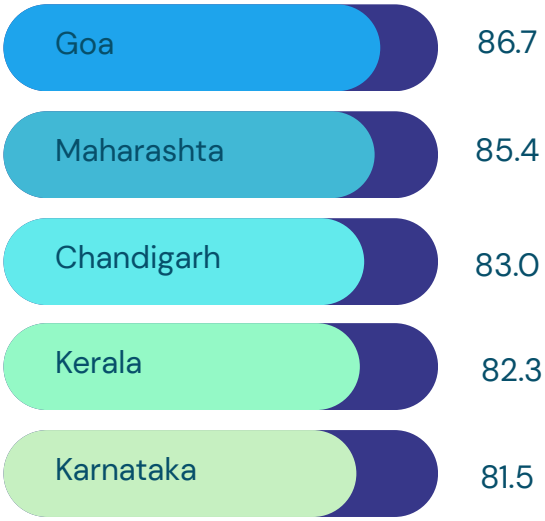
Gender	Mean	SE	t-value
Girls	81.1	0.03	91.3*
Boys	77	0.03	

*Significant at 0.05 level

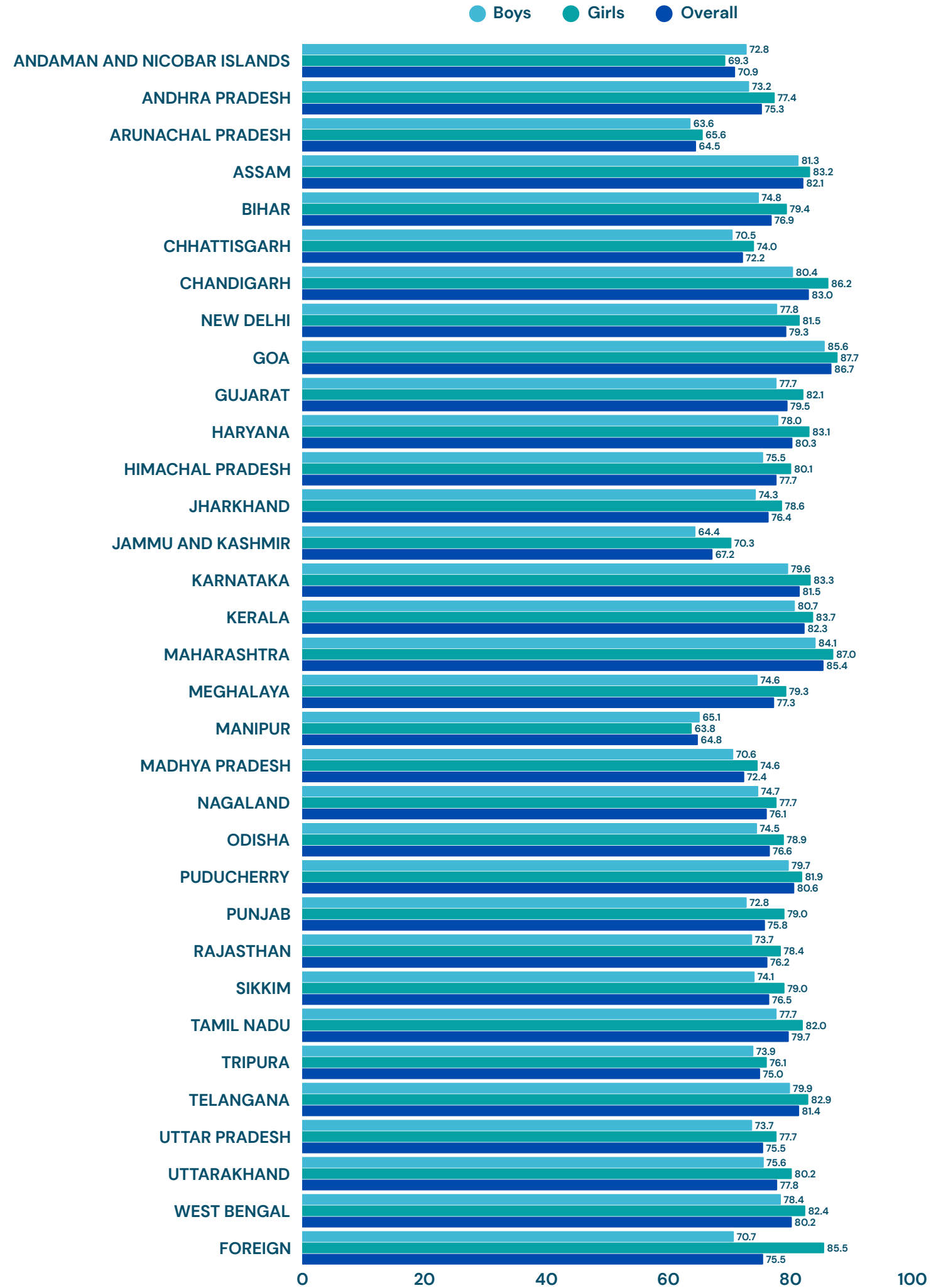
Region-wise Performance (Mean Marks)



Top 5 Perfoming States/UTs (Mean Marks)



Performance State-wise and Foreign (Mean Marks)



Question 1

[20]

*(Do not spend more than **30** minutes on this question.)*

Write a composition (300 - 350 words) on **any one** of the following:

(i) Write an original short story in which a poor tailor wins an award which changes his/her life.

(ii) Your friends once played a harmless prank on you. Give an account of what happened, your response to the prank and what you learnt from the experience.

(iii) Describe what you see and hear as you move about the corridors and compound during your school break time. How does the scene change after the bell rings?

(iv) *'More collaboration, less competition is the need of the hour'.*
Express your views either **for** or **against** this statement.

(v) Study the picture given below. Write a story or a description or an account of what it suggests to you. Your composition may be about the subject of the picture, or you may take suggestions from it; however, there must be a clear connection between the picture and your composition.



MARKING SCHEME	
(i)	The story must be original. The central character must be a poor tailor. There must be evidence of struggle, achievement, success and reward. A change in the circumstances should be indicated.
(ii)	This is a first-person account and must be narrated from within the plausible experience of a Class X candidate. There must be an understanding of the word 'prank'. Accept any trick, joke, harmless bit of mischief. Details of the prank, the response and the learning should come through clearly.
(iii)	Words of sight and feeling must form the main body of this composition. The noisy corridors, the children rushing around, eating tiffin, crowds near the taps etc to be described. It should conclude with the contrast – when the bell rings, everyone goes back to their classrooms and silence sets in.
(iv)	Views either for or against are to be accepted. The candidate should take a clear stand and give valid reasons for whatever stand he/she takes. Credit to be given for a cohesive well-constructed logical argument and ideas based on logical reasoning and personal experience.
(v)	Accept a wide interpretation. Any relevant ideas taken from the picture should be accepted. However, a ***mere itemisation /listing/description*** of the picture is to be penalised**.**

Comments of Examiners

(i) Majority of the candidates answered this question with varying degrees of linguistic ability. Some candidates insufficiently highlighted the struggles of the tailor, while others depicted how the tailor struggled to achieve, but in a profession other than tailoring. The character was also mistakenly identified as carpenter, teacher etc. In addition, some candidates ended the story at the award without highlighting how the event changed his//her life. Some candidates also appeared to have clearly borrowed the theme of their stories from local popular films.

(ii) Majority of the candidates could not highlight the lesson learnt from the experience, as it was either unclear or not understood by them. Some candidates misunderstood the idea of a harmless prank, describing harmful jokes or tricks instead. A few confused it with a clown's act or juggling, while others gave examples more typical of adults, such as office party pranks.

(iii) Many candidates attempted this question. Some described school break time adequately, with many capturing the scene in the corridors and compound vividly. However, only a few candidates brought out the change after the bell rings; for the majority, it appeared only as an afterthought. At the same time, the noise and chaos of break time and the quiet, discipline, and order afterwards were inadequately highlighted.

(iv) Majority of candidates could not make a clear distinction between the terms *collaboration* and *competition* and failed to take a clear stand. Both concepts were often confused due to limited vocabulary. Most candidates also struggled to provide adequate examples to support their arguments and were unable to relate the terms to real-life situations or data.

Suggestions for teachers

- Discuss the methodology to follow in short story writing and guide students on writing an original story.
- Emphasise plot structure, character building, dialogue writing that is minimal and effective.
- Guide students on how to write a logical ending especially cliffhanger.
- Recommend the works of different short story authors to be read for enrichment and creative guidance.
- Explain the difference between short story and narrative writing.
- Stress the need to carefully read and understand the question and making sure that each sub-part of the question is answered clearly, without overlap.
- Encourage the practise of writing first person narrative essays. Explain why these experiences should be age-appropriate or reflective of their present age. Point out clearly the difference between harmless and harmful, a joke and a prank.
- Teach students to understand the use of senses like the visual, auditory and tactile.
- Show how to read between the lines (for example, the sharp contrast between the chaos during break and the sudden calm after the bell rings).
- Ensure well-planned organisation of ideas.
- Avoid mere itemisation.
- Encourage students to add vivid details to their answers, include meaningful adjectives and adverbs to add depth to the description.
- Emphasise adding specific details alongside tools such as analogy, simile, and metaphor to add depth to descriptions.
- Encourage students to start with an interesting anecdote or idea for questions seeking a *for-or-against* stance.
- Emphasise that students need to present arguments through logical reasoning and to draw upon personal experience.

(v) Majority of the candidates did not attempt this question. Among those who did, themes such as poverty, joy in simplicity, and the contrast between the happiness of the poor and the dissatisfaction of the privileged were left incomplete. Many candidates referred to the rich, but the connection to the picture was not adequately established. Several candidates merely listed or itemised the elements in the picture instead of developing them meaningfully.

Suggestions for teachers

- Stress upon the need to take a clear stance as 'for' or 'against', develop 2–3 main points, and conclude effectively with a summary or engaging idea.
- Explain that examples and illustrations should be utilised into their answers to strengthen each argument.
- Advise students to avoid repetition in their arguments.
- Debates should be conducted in class regularly. Teach them to take a clear stand and justify with
- Instruct students to use a wide interpretation in their answers for essay type question and give free rein to their thought.
- Discourage mere itemisation of items from a picture-based question. Discuss and encourage them to discuss what the picture suggests and to explore a central idea.
- Discuss in class on the varied possibilities of approaching a picture composition - an account, a narrative, a story or a description.
- Explain to students how to think of the picture as the title or topic of the essay followed.
- Structure the composition using the rules for essay writing as prescribed with the various formats.

Question 2

[10]

*(Do not spend more than **20** minutes on this question.)*

Select ***anyone*** of the following:

(i) Your grandmother has taught you a special skill. Write a letter thanking her. Explain how you will use that skill and why it is important to you.

(ii) There is no bus stop in your locality. Write a letter to the Municipal Commissioner of your town/city complaining about the problem. Offer possible solutions.

MARKING SCHEME	
(i)	**Format** (Friendly/Informal letter) **Content** <u>*Details of the letter*</u> Thanking: e.g. thank you, I am so grateful/happy etc. *(Any one)* How you use that skill: e.g. decorate room, paint cards, help mother in kitchen, cook at weekends, rangoli at festivals, celebrations, teach a game like chess learnt from Grandma to other children etc. *(Any two)* Why is it important for you: e.g. empowering, it'll make me independent, I will be able to help others, stay occupied/ be able to contribute… etc. *(Any two)* **Expression** Opening and closing sentences, syntax, vocabulary and punctuation.
(ii)	**Format** (Formal letter) **Content** <u>*Details of the letter*</u> Complaints: e.g. walking long distances, delays, heavy school bags, inconvenience etc. *(Any two)* Suggestions: e.g. build a bus stop, give a shuttle service, encourage buses to stop even if there is no bus stop, post a policeman *(Any two)* **Expression** Opening and closing sentences, syntax, vocabulary and punctuation.

Comments of Examiners

(i) **Friendly Letter:**

Content: Majority of the candidates forgot to thank grandmother or even identify the skill. Many could not make out the difference between the usage of the skill and the importance of the skill in life.

Format: Candidates often misspelt 'February' in the date or used the short form 'Feb'. In many cases, the year was omitted, or the date was written in numbers. Many candidates also made common errors, including salutations with names such as 'Dear Grandmother Geeta', incorrect subscriptions like 'Your child, ABC' or the full name, misuse of the apostrophe in 'Yours' (written as 'Your's'), and the cursive *y*. However, overall expression was of better quality than in previous years or compared to Question 1.

(ii) **Formal Letter**

Content: Some candidates merely copied the question without identifying the problems, while others mentioned issues such as long distances to be walked and time lost. Many candidates failed to suggest plausible solutions, limiting themselves to asking the Municipal Commissioner to look into the matter or take necessary action. While most candidates identified building a bus stop as a solution, many offered only this one response.

Format: Common errors included misspelling 'February' in the date or writing it as 'Feb', omission of the year, or writing the date in numbers. In addition, salutations such as 'Respected Sir', informal subscriptions like 'Yours sincerely'/'Your humble servant', signing off with ABC or only the first name, misuse of the apostrophe in 'Yours' (written as 'Your's'), and the cursive *y* were frequently observed. The receiver's address was often incomplete, with only the city written after the designation. Overall, expression was better than in previous years or compared to Question 1, though some candidates still used casual or informal language.

Suggestions for teachers

- Teach students the difference between formal and friendly letter.
- Instruct students to read the question carefully to understand the points to be stressed upon.
- Teach flow of language and how each paragraph must be connected to the next.
- Guide students with the correct format for an informal letter (address, date, salutation, and subscription). Ensure addressing common errors such as spelling of February, adding full date on the letter, proper use of salutation as well as complementary closings or signoffs such as 'Yours lovingly', or 'Yours affectionately'.
- Encourage analysis of letter topic and teach how to address the different parts.
- Conduct classroom activities to improve language, structure and expression. Emphasise on tone appropriate to content.
- Encourage reading and discussion to improve language dexterity.
- Teach flow of language and how each paragraph must be connected to the next.
- Teach the candidates the correct format for formal letters (address, date, salutation, and subscription). Address common errors such as adding full date and the sender's and receiver's address. Reiterate that the receiver's address format beginning with the designation, followed by the name of the organisation.
- Teach the correct salutation, such as using as Sir, or Madam, and/or Dear but not Respected, and subscription, such as Yours faithfully, for a formal letter.
- Address adequately the importance of identifying key elements in a topic – the premise, the problems, the solutions, etc.
- Explain the necessity of ensuring precise language such that information given or required by the letter is included and extraneous details dispensed with.

Suggestions for teachers

- Avoid faulty language, use of contractions, short forms, informal or colloquial language.
- Share examples of good formal letters to give the students an understanding of what is required.
- Encourage candidates to read to improve their language skills, beyond their grammar practice.

Question 3

(i) Your school is hosting an Inter School Story Writing Competition. Write a notice informing the students about the event. **[5]**

(ii) Write an email to a famous person inviting him/her to be the Judge on the occasion. **[5]**

MARKING SCHEME	
(i)	Creative Title – e.g. *Weave a Tale, Telling Tales, Wordy Magic, Tall Tales, Tailing a Tale, Tell Tale* [recommended no word from the question is used for the creative title] Event: e.g. Inter School Story Writing Competition Date: Accept single date for example a week or fortnight away from the date of writing Time: e.g. 10.00 a.m. – 3.00 p.m. [no capital letters for a.m., p.m.] Venue: smaller place to larger Participation: All pupils who wish to register should give their names to the Vice Principal/etc on or before.
(ii)	E-mail – id Subject Salutation Opening sentence Closing sentence Subscription Expression – All details of the notice are to be included in the e-mail.

Comments of Examiners

(i) **In writing the Notice, the following errors were observed**:

- Several candidates incorporated words from the topic such as 'story' or 'writing' in their creative titles, while others chose vague titles like 'Burst of Talent', which could refer to any competition.
- Some wrote excessively long titles, even full sentences, and a few repeated War of Words, the title for debate competitions from the CISCE specimen paper.
- Dates of events were often inappropriate, set before the exam date, too soon after it, or unrealistically later than date of exam. Moreover, some candidates failed to clearly specify the venues, ranging from vague to overly broad, and registration details were frequently omitted. Placement of the date was also inconsistent, sometimes appearing after or too close to the event.
- Notices were often written as one long paragraph or included an unnecessary paragraph after the venue.

(ii) In writing the Notice, the following errors were observed:

- For the receiver's Gmail ID, few candidates incorrectly wrote the principal's address or even 'famousperson@gmail.com'. In the subject line, several candidates simply copied judge on occasion from the topic. Salutation and subscription errors were the same as those noted in letters. In content and expression, important details such as date, time, and venue were often missing, and many candidates added the invitation in the closing sentence itself.
- Some candidates also digressed by writing on unrelated topics such as music, dance, or wedding ceremonies instead of story writing.

Suggestions for teachers

- Advice students to refer to the CISCE website (www.cisce.org) to see the correct format for notice-writing.
- Explain that a creative title should be 'catchy', short and crisp (within 3 words), should not include words from the topic.
- Ensure that students also try to create titles which indicate the particular event.
- Clarify why the event in the question needs to be clearly mentioned in the answer with a justifying detail about how it is 'special' or significant.
- Emphasise on the necessity of sharing the required information as per the format. This includes the accurate details of the date, venue and time of the event.
- For notices, highlight that a single date be chosen and should also ideally be ten days to a fortnight away from the date of writing the notice.
- Emphasise that for any event mentioned, the venue should include details (name) of the hall, for example, and the institution.
- Encourage including key details in notices, such as where, with whom, and by which date to register. Explain the need for a gap between the registration deadline and the event date, with the deadline ideally set 2–3 days after the notice is issued.
- Practise composing creative titles to go with common events and competitions such as singing, music, drawing, dancing, elocution, debate, sports, swimming, etc.
- Familiarise students with the elements of an official email id but showing them a template o an actual email, email id etc.
- Explain to them the components of an email id: name of person/organisation. + @ + the provider.
- Instruct students to copy the event name into the subject box and to keep it short. They may at most add words like 'To judge…' or 'Invitation to attend…'

Suggestions for teachers

- Emphasise adding salutation and subscription as per formal letter rules.
- Emphasise that the opening sentence should clearly state the request or invitation and that the email must end with a polite closing to maintain proper tone and etiquette.
- Explain that event details must be included in the email and must match the notice for accuracy and consistency.
- Guide classroom discussions on differentiating between personal and official email IDs and to read the question very carefully.

Question 4

Read the following passage carefully and answer the questions that follow:

A little later, when he went to the pump to wash, he saw the school children pouring by with their ***satchels*** across their shoulders. They all wore the same clothes – grey shorts or skirts and light blue shirts or blouses – faded and mended, and they all had their hair oiled and combed down very flat. Some went by in laughing, racing groups, others had to be led by their mothers or grandparents to the school building. This reminded him of his sisters in the village.

The boys in the kitchen now looked at him with less hostility. Jagu seemed pleased with Hari too, and sometimes handed him a glass of tea in the middle of the day. When he had a few moments to ***spare***, Jagu sat down at one of the long wooden tables, drummed loudly on it and sang a song in a dialect Hari did not know. When he caught Hari listening and smiling, he smiled back. Then Hari knew that he too had a village somewhere that he called home. It was just that he was a silent, hardworking, worried man and had no time and no gift for speech. 10

It was the watch mender, Mr. Panwallah, who was truly a benefactor, the kindest and most helpful of all. One afternoon, during those hot, still hours when there were no customers for a change, Hari was standing in front of the eating house, idly watching the traffic because he 20

was too tired to do anything else, and Mr. Panwallah called to him to come and sit beside him on the bench behind the counter in his shop. 30

"Want to help?" he asked. "Want to learn how to make a clock tick? I'm just going to open this big grandfather clock sent to me for repair – you'll be able to see the workings plain. Don't often get a piece like this anymore – wall clocks, yes, and electronic gadgets – but you don't often come upon a grandfather clock like this. It's a real piece of luck, being able to show you one of this size. Look," he said, swinging open the door at the back and revealing the machinery to a fascinated Hari who felt as if the door had opened into a new and strange house. Mr. Panwallah showed Hari what was wrong with it, what had made it stop. "Interesting, isn't it? How would you like to learn? Tell you what – I'll take you on as an apprentice. You don't have much to do between two and four, do you? Of course you will have to ask Jagu first. I can pay you a little, not much, and you can help me for two hours a day.Perhaps I can make a watch mender of you."

— *Village by the Sea, Anita Desai*

(i) For each word given below choose the correct meaning (as used in the passage) from the options provided: **[2]**

1. satchels *(line 2)*

   (a) snatching

   (b) scarves

   (c) school bags

   (d) sweaters

2. spare *(line 10)*

   (a) share

   (b) offer

   (c) thin

   (d) extra

(ii) Which word in the passage is the opposite of 'closed'? **[1]**

(a) behind

(b) fascinated

(c) opened

(d) revealing

(iii) Answer the following questions briefly in your own words:

(a) How were the school children dressed? **[2]**

(b) In what way was Jagu kind to Hari? **[2]**

(c) What did the song tell Hari about Jagu? **[1]**

(d) Which sentence in the passage tells us that Jagu was not a talkative man? **[2]**

(e) Why were there no customers at that time of the day? **[2]**

(iv) In not more than 50 words describe how Mr. Panwallah introduced Hari to watch mending. **[8]**

MARKING SCHEME

(i)	1. (c) school bags 2. (d) extra
(ii)	(c) opened
(iii)	(a) Grey shorts and skirts / light blue shirts or blouses / faded and mended / hair oiled and combed flat. (b) Glass of tea / middle of the day.
	(c) That Jagu had a village somewhere / that he called home.
	(d) It was just that he was a silent, hardworking, worried man and had no time and no gift for speech.
	(e) It was too hot and still.
(iv)	<u>Points:</u> 1. come and sit 2. Want to help? 3. open/show him the working of the grandfather clock 4. make an apprentice

	5. between two and four 6. ask Jagu 7. pay you little 8. two hours a day (*Any 6 points in correct sequence*)

Comments of Examiners

(i) 1. Several candidates misinterpreted the meanings without contextual reference; 'satchels' was mistakenly identified as option (b) instead of (c).

2. Many candidates incorrection chose option (a) or (b).

(ii) Majority of the candidates answered this question correctly.

(iii) (a) Majority of the candidates answered this question correctly. However, some candidates mentioned just one part of the uniform/dress, while others confused the colours.

(b) Majority of the candidates answered this question correctly.

(c) Most candidates answered this correctly. However, a few candidates failed to identify that the song revealed to Hari that Jagu had a village called home; instead, they described 'how' the song was sung. Some candidates also misinterpreted the song as reflecting Jagu's kindness or simply his love for singing.

(d) Many candidates quoted more than one sentence while other quoted a few phrases. A few candidates wrote in their own words or paraphrased the sentence instead of quoting as required.

(e) Majority of the candidates missed the word 'still' when explaining the reason for the lack of customers, and some candidates appeared not to understand its meaning in the context of the story.

(iv) Summary Writing: Candidates appeared to struggle with drafting a summary. Several candidates wrote the summary from the preceding paragraph and failed to identify most of the key points. Majority of the candidates also exceeded the word limit and failed to draw grids or provide rough summaries. Many candidates were unable to elucidate the points in their answer despite

Suggestions for teachers

- Instruct students to read the passage carefully and to note the meaning of the words as used in context.
- Explain how if the incorrect word or form of the word is used, it would not fit in the passage.
- Encourage candidates to practise vocabulary exercises and look up words in a dictionary where required.
- Promote regular reading and the noting of impactful, similar-sounding, and synonymous words.
- Instruct students to read the passage carefully and to note the meaning of the words as used in context.
- Clarify to students that an incorrect word or form affects the coherence and meaning of the passage.
- Promote regular vocabulary exercises and dictionary use when needed.
- Train students in identifying 'opposites' by using various grammar exercises/games.
- Remind students to read the entire relevant section of the passage and include all key details in their answers.
- Ensure students develop comprehension skills by working with diverse texts and exploring different forms of literature.
- Advise students to read the comprehension passage multiple times until they fully understand it.
- Promote original expression over copying and encourage critical reading strategies to enhance deeper understanding.
- Provide more practice with interpreting context clues to develop inference skills.
- Ensure that such higher order thinking questions are a part of every comprehension exercise.
- Train students to read the question carefully, find the exact sentence in the passage, and reproduce it word-for-word when quoting.
- Emphasise the distinction between phrases, clauses, and sentences, and train students to write full sentences with no omissions.

appearing to know the actual points. Moreover, most answers focused only on the opening of the watch and becoming an apprentice.

Suggestions for teachers

- Train in grid drawing, and on writing rough and fair drafts.
- Explain how to identify key points and leave out extra details such as adjectives used to embellish.
- Guide students to look for naming words, doing words, events etc. as focal points.
- Teach how to write single words instead of phrases, phrases instead of clauses (for example 'throne of gold' instead of 'throne which was made of gold'), punctuation and etc. judiciously to avoid repetition.
- Remind students not to leave out articles and prepositions. Tell them using correct expression is very important in a summary.

Question 5

(i) Fill in each of the numbered blanks with the correct form of the word given in brackets. Do not copy the passage but write in correct serial order the word or phrase appropriate to the blank space. **[4]**

Example:

One day we (0) _____ (lift) the box up.

Answer: (0) lifted

We (1) _____ (find) a dead mouse (2) _____ (lie) among our treasures. It (3) _____ (be) an exciting discovery. A boy took it up by its tail and(4) _____ (wave) it in front of our faces.

"What shall we do with it?" he (5) _____ (cry). "It stinks!" someone (6) _____ (shout).

"Throw it out of the window quick!"

He (7) _____ (hesitate).They all (8) _____ (look) at me.

(ii) Fill in the blanks with appropriate words. **[4]**

(a) My best friend, John is named _____ his grandfather.

(b) A grey mist hung _____ the fields.

(c) The little girl spoke _____ against the bully.

(d) They accused him _____ theft.

(e) The police got the fire _____ control.

(f) There is a bridge _____ the river.

(g) The driver jumped _____ the car.

(h) I have not seen my uncle _____ last summer.

(iii) Choose the correct option to make one complete sentence **without using *and, but*** or ***so***. **[4]**

1. These are fresh mangoes. I bought them yesterday.

   (a) These are fresh mangoes which I bought yesterday.

   (b) These mangoes were fresher when I bought them yesterday.

   (c) These are fresh mangoes which were bought yesterday.

   (d) These are fresh mangoes brought by me yesterday.

2. The debating teams were very happy. They were declared joint champions.

   (a) The debating teams were very happy as they have been declared joint champions.

   (b) The debating teams are very happy as they are declared joint champions.

   (c) The debating teams were very happy as they had been declared joint champions.

   (d) The debating teams will be very happy as they will be declared joint champions.

3. The rain came down. All the people ran away.

   (a) When the rain came down, all the people ran away.

   (b) When it rained, the people ran away.

   (c) The rain had come down all the people ran away.

   (d) The rain having come, all the people ran away.

4. The disciple was wise. The teacher did not trust him.

   (a) Although the disciple was wise yet the teacher trusted him.

   (b) Although the disciple was not wise the teacher trusted him.

   (c) Although the disciple is wise, the teacher trusted him.

   (d) Although the disciple was wise, the teacher did not trust him.

(iv) Choose the correct option and rewrite the sentence according to the instruction given after each. **[8]**

1. The teacher said, "Come early tomorrow, the examination begins at eight o'clock."

   (Begin: The teacher told us to……..)

   (a) The teacher told us to come early the next day as the examination would begin at eight o'clock.

   (b) The teacher told us to come early tomorrow as the examination begins at eight o'clock.

   (c) The teacher told us the examination will begin at eight o'clock so come early tomorrow.

   (d) The teacher told us to come by eight o'clock as the examination will begin early the next day.

2. Rahul not only plays the guitar but also the drums.

   (Use: 'as well as')

   (a) Rahul plays the guitar as well as the drums.

   (b) Rahul plays the guitar as well the drums.

   (c) Rahul plays the guitar as well as he does the drums.

   (d) Rahul play's the guitar and the drums as well.

3. She said she would not be available.

   (Add a question tag)

   (a) Didn't she say that she would not be available?

   (b) She said she would not be available, did she?

   (c) She said she would not be available, didn't she?

   (d) She said she would not be available, wouldn't she?

4. This is the most beautiful painting in the exhibition.

   (Begin: No other……)

   (a) No other painting is as beautiful as this exhibition.

   (b) No other painting in this exhibition is beautiful.

   (c) No other painting is beautiful as this painting in the exhibition.

(d) No other painting in the exhibition is as beautiful as this one.

5. I prefer aerobics to yoga.

(Use: 'rather')

(a) I would rather do aerobics to yoga.

(b) I would rather do aerobics than yoga.

(c) I would rather prefer aerobics than yoga.

(d) I would rather do yoga than aerobics.

6. The coach taught the children the rules of the game.

(Begin: The rules……)

(a) The rules have being taught by the coach to the children.

(b) The rules of the game have been taught by the children to the coach.

(c) The rules of the game is taught by the coach to the children.

(d) The rules of the game were taught by the coach to the children.

7. No sooner did the film star arrive than the crowd cheered.

(Begin: As soon as……)

(a) As soon as the film star arrived then the crowd cheered.

(b) As soon as the film star arrives the crowd starts cheering.

(c) As soon as the crowd cheers the film star arrives.

(d) As soon as the film star arrived the crowd cheered.

8. School bags are often too heavy for students to carry.

(Use: 'so')

(a) School bags are so heavy students cannot carry them.

(b) School bags are often so heavy that students cannot carry them.

(c) School bags are often so heavy for students to carry.

(d) School bags are heavy so students cannot carry them.

MARKING SCHEME	
(i)	[0. lifted] 1. found 2. lying 3. was 4. waved 5. cried 6. shouted 7. hesitated 8. looked
(ii)	(a) after (b) over (c) up (d) of (e) under (f) across/over (g) into (h) since
(iii)	1. (a) These are fresh mangoes which I bought yesterday. 2. (c) The debating teams were very happy as they had been declared joint champions. 3. (a) When the rain came down, all the people ran away. 4. (d) Although the disciple was wise, the teacher did not trust him.
(iv)	1. (a) The teacher told us to come early the next day as the examination would begin at eight o'clock. 2. (a) Rahul plays the guitar as well as the drums. 3. (c) She said she would not be available, didn't she? 4. (d) No other painting in the exhibition is as beautiful as this one. 5. (b) I would rather do aerobics than yoga. 6. (d) The rules of the game were taught by the coach to the children. 7. (d) As soon as the film star arrived the crowd cheered. 8. (b) Schoolbags are often so heavy that students cannot carry them.

Comments of Examiners

(i) Majority of the candidates made spelling errors some of which include: (2) 'lying' written as 'lieing', (5) 'cried' as 'cryed' rather than in tenses, (3) 'being' or 'become' instead of 'was', (8) 'were looking' instead of 'looked'.

(ii) While majority of the candidates got a few of the questions correct, some of the common errors observed for this question were:
(a) 'for' instead of 'after'
(c) 'Out' instead of 'up'
(e) 'into' instead of ''under'
(g) 'off' instead of 'into'
Some candidates wrote more than one answer.

(iii) (1) Majority of the candidates answered correctly. However, some chose (d) mistaking the word 'brought' for 'bought'. In some answers, the option number did not the statement chosen. A few candidates used shortcuts such as using dots instead of words to complete the sentences. Example: "(a) These are fresh mangoes…".

(2) Many candidates incorrectly chose option (a) instead of (c).

(3) Majority of the candidates answered correctly.

(4) Majority of the candidates answered correctly.

(iv) (1) Majority of the candidates were not clear about the rules for changing direct speech to indirect speech, leading to incorrect option choices.

(2) Some candidates chose option (c), likely due to not reading the stem carefully. They interpreted 'also' as indicating the degree of playing skill, showing an incorrect understanding of sentence construction.

(3) Many candidates incorrectly chose (b) instead of (c).

(4) Many candidates were unable to interpret the meanings of the sentences, particularly in relation to comparison, grammar, and sentence

Suggestions for teachers

- Incorporate more contextual grammar practice and use of narrative texts to reinforce tense consistency.
- Reinforce the correct usage of tenses and verb forms in sentences, especially the forms of 'be' verb.
- Encourage regular reading to help students familiarise themselves with the correct spellings of words, use of prepositions, adverbs, and general grammar.
- Instruct students to read the complete sentence and understand the context before deciding on the preposition.
- Instruct the students to write the option as well as the statement and to match the two carefully.
- Emphasise on the need to answer with complete sentences.
- Advise them that meaning and context should align with the tense in the given statement.
- Practise sentence synthesis by retaining causal links with necessary changes in tense or parts of speech, and by using simple, complex, and compound clauses.
- Teach students, with examples, that sentences may be merged to show a causal relationship or to express contrast or concession. For instance, an 'Although' clause or 'in spite of the fact that' introduces a statement that makes the main clause seem surprising or unexpected.
- Emphasise on the importance of reading all the options carefully before choosing the correct statement.
- Revise the rules for forming sentences with degrees of comparison.
- Explain redundancy in expressions like 'would rather prefer'.
- Emphasise on the importance of reading all the options carefully before choosing the correct statement.

construction rubric. As a result, they chose option (c) incorrectly and overlooked the correct option (d).

(5) Most candidates incorrectly chose (c) presuming that 'rather prefer' can be used together.

(6) Most candidates made mistakes in Active–Passive conversion, mainly in handling tense, while some carelessly chose option (b).

(7) Some candidates incorrectly chose option (a), interpreting 'then the crowd…' as a reference to the time factor in 'As soon as'.

(8) Many candidates were not clear about the use of 'so...that' and wrote option (c) instead of the correct answer (b).

Suggestions for teachers

- Practise sentence transformation with focus on:
  - direct and indirect speech, including multiple subjects.
  - Prepositions in context, and through examples and sentence completion tasks.
  - question tags, noting that positive statements usually take negative tags and negative statements take positive tags, with some exceptions;
  - comparison and correct sentence construction.
  - precise word usage without repetition of similar words or ideas in close succession.
  - Active-Passive voice and tense accuracy.
  - identifying actions that occur as a consequence or result of something else.
  - the proper use of 'so…that' structures with interactive exercises.
- Teaching cause-effect relationships using examples and highlighting usage of the correct conjunction in a given sentence.

GENERAL COMMENTS

Topics found difficult by candidates

- **Question 1:** Short scripts, some candidates also did not attempt or provided only single paragraphs.
- **Question 1:** Spelling errors such as *there-their, principal-principle, tailor-taylor*, 'stiched' with a 't' missing…
- **Question 1 (iii):** The word 'collaboration' in the argumentative essay.
- **Question 2 (ii):** Addressing all parts of the letter and providing solutions to problems in the formal letter.
- **Question 3:** Absence of catchy title, dates other relevant details in the notice that provide a practical framework.
- **Question 4:** Summary writing in comprehension.
- **Question 5:** Correct grammatical usage such depending on context. Additionally, incorrect tense, especially use of present continuous where not appropriate
- **Question 5 (ii):** Prepositions in the grammar section. Rules in sentence construction.
- **Question 5 (iv):** Incorrect rubric and incorrect sentence construction.
- **In General**
  - Errors in Punctuation: no full stops, commas or question marks, comma put in wrong place
  - Use of contractions and colloquial or informal language such as referring to children as 'kids', 'gonna' instead of 'going to', Indianisms
  - Incorporating suggested directions from the comprehension or essay topic: candidates copied the comprehension or essay topics in full or part, depending upon whether they were able (fluent enough in English) to write some part of the essay/or not at all.

Concepts in which candidates got confused

- **Question 1:** In the argumentative essay, the difference in meaning in the two key words – collaboration and competition.
- **Question 2:** Misinterpretation of the word 'skill' in the friendly letter.
- **Question 3: C**andidates often mistook the topic as 'Writing' rather than 'Short Story Writing.'
- **Question 4**: The vocabulary portion showed mistakes in conception.
- **Question 5:** Grammatical concepts in tense, article, preposition

Suggestions for candidates

- Read all the questions carefully and the instructions given on the question paper.
- Thoroughly read the comprehension passage carefully and comprehend it before answering the questions.
- Make sure that the length of the composition should be strictly in accordance with the word limit mentioned on the question paper.
- Inculcate a reading habit and read a variety of books to improve basic language skills and fluency. Focus on the sentence construction in the books that you read.
- For essays and compositions, divide content into coherent paragraphs.
- Practise sentence construction with interactive exercises.
- Familiarise and identify important key details in the format of Emails (informal/formal) and notices to mandatorily add into your writing exercises.
- Recheck all answers during examinations to ensure that the correct serial number has been added to each answer, especially for MCQs.
- Pay close attention to punctuation, revise the basic rules and practise regularly with examples.
- Gain a thorough understanding of tense usage and subject-verb agreement by studying the rules and practicing relevant exercises.
- Practice using precise language while answering questions.
- Solve competency-focused practice questions, past years' ICSE board papers and specimen question papers within the stipulated time.
- Follow the format of letters, notice, Email and precis writing as prescribed on www.cisce.org.